

LESSON 4

Personalizing the Text: Suffixes and Possession

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 3

Quick Summary

In Lesson 3, we examined the Peal Perfect tense (the suffix conjugation), learning how Syriac describes completed, past actions. The sentence structure shifted from fluidly subject-led (in the present participle) to stringently Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) led narrative chains using the conjunction **w-** (and).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What does the suffix **-ū** indicate on a Perfect verb (e.g., *ktabū*)?
2. Translate the basic VSO sentence: *Shbaq malkā l- 'ar 'ā*.
3. What happens to the pronunciation of *k-t-b* (ka-tab) in the Syriac 3rd m.sg Perfect?
4. How do you distinguish between “I went” and “You (m) went” if both are written ܬܒܬܬ (*ktabt/ketbet*) without vowels?
5. Translate: *w-qreb Yūḥannan*.

SECTION 2: POSSESSION AND PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES — OVERVIEW

In English, we indicate possession using separate pronouns placed before a noun: “my house”, “your king”. In Greek, it’s often an independent genitive pronoun: ὁ οἶκός μου (*ho oikos mou*).

However, in Semitic languages, possession is expressed by attaching a **pronominal suffix** directly to the end of the noun.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Possessive Suffix

- **Hebrew:** סוס (*sūs*, horse) → סוסי (*sūsī*, my horse). אב (*'āb*, father) → אבננו (*'ābīnū*, our father).
- **Arabic:** كتاب (*kitāb*, book) → كتابي (*kitābī*, my book).
- **Syriac:** ܬܒܬܬ (*ktāb*, book) → ܬܒܬܬܝ (*ktāby*, my book). ܐܒ (*'ab*, father) → ܐܒܢܝ (*'abūn*, our father).

These suffixes are derived from the same ancient roots as the independent pronouns (*ʿenā*, *ʿant*, *hū*) but are highly compressed.

SECTION 3: PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES ON NOUNS & PREPOSITIONS

1. Suffixes on Singular Nouns

To add a suffix, Syriac uses the Absolute state of the noun, not the Emphatic state. (You don't say "the my-king" **malkā-y* ; you say "king-my", *malk-y*).

- *Malk-* (king) + *-eh* (his) = *malkeh* (his king).
- *ʿAb-* (father) + *-y* (my) = *ʿaby* (my father).

2. Suffixes on Prepositions

The exact same suffixes attach to the inseparable prepositions *b-* (in) and *l-* (to/for).

- *b-* + *-eh* = *beh* (in him / in it).
- *l-* + *-k* = *lāk* (to you, m.sg).

3. The Idiom for "To Have"

Syriac (like Hebrew and Arabic) lacks a dedicated verb meaning "to possess" (like English "to have" or Latin "habere"). Instead, Semitic languages use a prepositional phrase: "there is to me" or just "to me".

- *īt l-y* (there-is to-me) → *ītly* = I have.
 - *layt l-eh* (there-is-not to-him) = He does not have.
 - *ītly srārā* = I have truth. (Lit: There is to me truth).
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SECTION 4: THE SUFFIX PARADIGM FOR SINGULAR NOUNS

This paradigm uses the masculine noun *malk-* (king, root m-l-k) and the feminine noun *malkūtt-* (kingdom). Notice the suffix column; you must memorize these endings.

PERSON	SUFFIX	MASCULINE NOUN (MALK-)	TRANSLIT	FEM NOUN (MALKŪTT-)	TRANSLIT
1 c.sg. (my)	ﻱ (-y)	ﻣﺎﻟﻚ	malk-y	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻱ	malkūtt-y
2 m.sg. (your)	ﻛ (-k)	ﻣﺎﻟﻚ	malk-āk	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻛ	malkūtt-āk
2 f.sg. (your)	ﻛﻲ (-ky)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﻲ	malk-ēky	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻛﻲ	malkūtt-ēky
3 m.sg. (his)	ﻩ (-eh)	ﻣﺎﻟﻚ	malk-eh	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻩ	malkūtt-eh
3 f.sg. (her)	ﻩ (-āh)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﻪ	malk-āh	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻩ	malkūtt-āh
1 c.pl. (our)	ﻧ (-n)	ﻣﺎﻟﻚ	malk-an	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻥ	malkūtt-an
2 m.pl. (your)	ﻛﯘﻥ (-kūn)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﻥ	malk-kūn	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻛﯘﻥ	malkūtt-kūn
2 f.pl. (your)	ﻛﻪﻥ (-kēn)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﻪﻥ	malk-kēn	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻛﻪﻥ	malkūtt-kēn
3 m.pl. (their)	ﻫﯘﻥ (-hūn)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﻥ	malk-hūn	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻫﯘﻥ	malkūtt-hūn
3 f.pl. (their)	ﻫﻪﻥ (-hēn)	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﻪﻥ	malk-hēn	ﻣﺎﻟﻜﯘﺗﺖﻫﻪﻥ	malkūtt-hēn

Orthography Note: The 3rd masculine singular (-eh) and 3rd feminine singular (-āh) are both spelled with a final Heh (ﻩ). Only vowel pointing or context distinguishes “his” from “her”.

SECTION 5: PREPOSITIONAL "TO HAVE" PARADIGM (L- + SUFFIX)

How to say "I have", "You have", "He has", etc., by attaching suffixes to the **l-** preposition, often preceded by *it* (there is).

PERSON	ESTRANGELA (L- + SUFFIX)	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING
1 c.sg.	ل	lī	to me (I have)
2 m.sg.	لك	lāk	to you (You have)
2 f.sg.	لكي	lēky	to you (You have)
3 m.sg.	له	lēh	to him (He has)
3 f.sg.	له	lāh	to her (She has)
1 c.pl.	لنا	lān	to us (We have)
2 m.pl.	لكم	lkūn	to you (You all have)
3 m.pl.	لهم	lhūn	to them (They have)

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (FAMILY, BODY PARTS & BELONGINGS)

Family and body parts are the most common nouns to receive pronominal suffixes.

ABSOLUTE / EMPHATIC	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING	EXAMPLE WITH SUFFIX (1 C.SG.)
אב / אבא	'ab / 'abā	Father	'ab-y (my father)
אמ / אמא	'em / 'emmā	Mother	'em-y (my mother)
בר / ברא	bar / brā	Son	bar-y (my son)
בת / בראתא	bart / brattā	Daughter	bart-y (my daughter)
אח / אחא	'ah / 'ahā	Brother	'ah-y (my brother)
יד / ידא	'id / 'idā	Hand (f)	'id-y (my hand)
ראש / ראשא	rēš / rēšā	Head (m)	rēš-y (my head)
קול / קולא	qāl / qālā	Voice (m)	qāl-y (my voice)
לבוש / לבושא	lbūš / lbūšā	Garment	lbūš-y (my garment)
בית / ביתא	bēt / baytā	House	bayt-y (my house)
מא / מאא	mā / mānā	What?	(Interrogative pronoun)
איבער	'aykō	Where?	(Interrogative adverb)

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 4

A Dialogue at the Gate

*Narrative note: Watch how the guards use suffixes with prepositions (*lēh* , *lḵūn*) and nouns (*'abūk* , *'emāk*) to interrogate Yūḥannan about his origins and possessions.*

Sentence 1

אמא דמלכותא קאם יוֹחָנָן ב-תַּרְא ד-מַלְכֻּתָּא. qām Yūḥannan b-tar 'ā d-malküttā. qām (stood) Yūḥannan (John) b-tar 'ā (in-the-gate) d-malküttā (of-the-kingdom). → Yūḥannan stood at the gate of the kingdom.

Sentence 2

וְאֵלֵּי הַשַּׁרְיָסִים וְאֵלֵּי הַשַּׁרְיָסִים w- 'āmrīn qašīšē d-tar 'ā l-ēh: w- 'āmrīn (and-are-saying) qašīšē (the-elders/guards) d-tar 'ā (of-the-gate) l-ēh (to-him): → And the guards of the gate say to him:

Sentence 3

מֵאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה מֵאֵי מְדִינָה men 'aynā 'atrā 'ant? men (from) 'aynā (what) 'atrā (country/place) 'ant (you-[are])? → “From what country are you?”

Sentence 4

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה w- 'aykō 'ab-ūk w- 'em-āk? w- 'aykō (and-where) 'ab-ūk (father-your) w- 'em-āk (and-mother-your)? → “And where is your father and your mother?”

Sentence 5

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה w-mā it lāk b- 'īd-āk? w-mā (and-what) it (there-is) lāk (to-you) b- 'īd-āk (in-hand-your)? → “And what do you have in your hand?”

Sentence 6

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה 'emar l-hūn Yūḥannan: 'emar (said) l-hūn (to-them) Yūḥannan (John): → Yukhannan said to them:

Sentence 7

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה Alāhā hū 'ab-y, w- 'ar 'ā hī 'em-y. Alāhā (God) hū (he-[is]) 'ab-y (father-my), w- 'ar 'ā (and-the-earth) hī (she-[is]) 'em-y (mother-my). → “God is my father, and the earth is my mother.”

Sentence 8

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה w-layt lī lbūšā bīšā. w-layt (and-there-is-not) lī (to-me) lbūšā (a-garment) bīšā (evil). → “And I do not have an evil garment.”

Sentence 9

וְאֵי מְדִינָה אַתָּה אִי מְדִינָה nūhrā d-Alāhā it-awhy b- 'īd-y. nūhrā (the-light) d-Alāhā (of-God) it-awhy (it-is) b- 'īd-y (in-hand-my). → “The light of God is in my hand.”

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

Identify the person, gender, and number of the possessor for the following suffixed nouns.

1. ܡܠܟܐ (malk-an)
2. ܒܝܬܐ (bayt-eh)
3. ܐܝܕܐ (ʾīd-ēky)
4. ܡܠܟܘܬܐ (malkūt-hūn)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill (Possession)

Translate the following phrases using ܐܝܬ- + suffix (using *īt* where appropriate to mean “have”):

1. To you (f.sg).
2. We have (There is to us).
3. He does not have (There is not to him).
4. To them (m.pl).

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following sentences containing suffixed nouns.

1. ʾAbī ṭābā hū, w-ʾemī ṭābtā hī.
2. Šbaqū talmīdē l-baythūn.
3. Īt lān nūhrā rabbā.
4. Qālā d-malkā b-ʾarʿan (ʾarʿ-an).

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following sentences into Syriac transliteration.

1. My brother is writing a word.
2. The king and his son are going to his kingdom.
3. What is in your (m.sg) hand?
4. We do not have (*layt lān*) an evil king.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. Under what three topics does the guard interrogate Yuxhannan?
 2. Who does Yuxhannan claim as his parents?
 3. What does Yuxhannan explicitly state he *does not* have?
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SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. 3rd person masculine plural (“they”).
2. The king left the earth.
3. The *a* vowel in the middle of the root disappears (vowel reduction), making it *ktab* (k-t-a-b).
4. Only context or vowel pointing.
5. And Yuxhannan drew near.

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

1. 1st common plural (Our king)
2. 3rd masc singular (His house)
3. 2nd fem singular (Your hand)
4. 3rd masc plural (Their kingdom)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. lēky
2. īt lān
3. layt lēh
4. lhūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. My father is good, and my mother is good.
2. The disciples left their house (*bayt-hūn*).
3. We have a great light (There is to us a great light).
4. The voice of the king is in our land (‘ar ‘-an = ‘ar ‘ā + -an).

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. ' aḥ-y kāteb meltā.
2. Malkā w-bar-eh ' āzlin l-malkūtt-eh.
3. Mā it b- ' id-āk?
4. Layt lān malkā bīšā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. Origin (what country), Family (where are father/mother), and Possessions (what is in hand).
 2. God (father) and the earth (mother).
 3. An evil garment (*lbūšā bīšā*).
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SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PRONOMINAL SUFFIXES (ATTACH TO NOUNS AND PREPOSITIONS)

SUFFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLE (BAYT- HOUSE)	EXAMPLE (L- TO)
-y	my	baytī (my house)	lī (to me)
-k	your (m)	baytāk (your house)	lāk (to you)
-ky	your (f)	baytēky (your house)	lēky (to you)
-eh	his	bayteh (his house)	lēh (to him)
-āh	her	baytāh (her house)	lāh (to her)
-an	our	baytan (our house)	lān (to us)
-kūn	your (pl)	baytkūn (your house)	lkūn (to you all)
-hūn	their (pl)	baythūn (their house)	lhūn (to them)

SAYING “TO HAVE” (Possession Formula)

FORMULA	SYRIAC	MEANING
ĪT + L- + Suffix	īt lī / itly	I have (There is to me)
LAYT + L- + Suffix	layt lēh	He does not have
ĪT + L- + Suffix	īt lhūn malkā	They have a king

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson's vocabulary to 18 terms.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܟܬܐܢܐ	sputā	f. noun	lip	emphatic state
ܬܠܓܓܐ	talggā	m. noun	ridge, back	
ܟܝܪܐ	ṣirē	f. noun	side, rib	
ܟܢܒܐ	ganbā	m. noun	thigh	
ܕܪܐܐ	dar ʿ ā	f. noun	arm	
ܟܠܦܐ	ʿaggālā	m. noun	calf (leg part)	
ܟܬܢܐ	ḥatnā	m. noun	bridegroom	
ܟܬܢܐ	kaltā	f. noun	bride	
ܟܝܡܪܐ	ʿammūrā	m. noun	uncle (paternal)	
ܟܬܡܐ	ʿammtā	f. noun	aunt (paternal)	
ܟܡܩܐ	ʿammqā	m. adj	deep	
ܟܦܬܐ	paltā	m. noun	escape, safety	
ܟܬܝܪܐ	ʿattirā	m. adj	rich, mighty	
ܟܡܟܢܐ	meskennā	m. adj	poor, humble	
ܟܝܒܒܐܪܐ	gibbōrā	m. adj	mighty, strong	
ܟܠܠܐ	qallilā	m. adj	small, few	
ܟܝܠܕܐ	yḥiddā	m. adj	alone, unique	
ܟܕܠܐ	ʿaddālā	m. adj	just, righteous	